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Published by

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Estimated reading time

3 min

Added on

2026-06-15

Address

<https://www.football365.com/news/opinion-van-dijk-coddled-no-avail-netherlands-parody-liverpool-japan-draw>

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We saw the best of Virgil van Dijk but mainly his waning physicality as the Netherlands did an excellent Liverpool impression in their draw with Japan.

A game billed as one of the highlights as the group stage left plenty to be desired in the first half. We endured two teams terrified of making a mistake defending with five at the back and attacking with forwards failing to take the initiative or responsibility to beat a man and create a chance. It was painful viewing.

Donyell Malen, who was given the nod ahead of Memphis Depay to lead the line for the Netherlands, forced a couple of relatively simple saves from Zion Suzuki and that was pretty much the extent of the excitement as a Japan side famed for its relentless pressing and high energy were strangely timid against a team doing an excellent Liverpool impression.

It was suggested on commentary that recently sacked Reds boss Arne Slot might be next in line to lead the Oranje when Ronald Koeman's contract expires at the end of the World Cup, and the transition would be seamless on the basis of the first 45 minutes in the Dallas Stadium.

"There's a point when it becomes too predictable," said Ally McCoist as Cody Gakpo somehow managed to cut inside more often than he had possession of the ball while Liverpool fans the world over nodded sagely in recognition of their chief scapegoat's greatest flaw and only apparent skill.

Mention of Ryan Gravenberch's name in the 35th minute announced his participation in a game in which slow side-to-side passing rendered him largely redundant.

The key difference in what we saw from the Netherlands' Liverpool faction was the degree with which [Virgil van Dijk](#) was coddled through proceedings as Frenkie de Jong was asked to drop into the defence when the Dutch were out of possession to protect the Reds legend, who was still caught out on a couple of occasions even with that failsafe in place.

"He's got to get tighter there," McCoist said on commentary as Shogo Taniguchi got to the byline and crossed for Daizen Maeda while Van Dijk stood and watched early in proceedings, before Ayase Ueda drifted away from the Dutch captain all too easily to get a snap shot away later in the first half. The way Van Dijk turned one way and then the other to work out where the Japanese striker was particularly damning.

We owe him for the two key moments in this game. He displayed his wonderful ability in the opposition box, stooping expertly to direct his header from an excellent Gravenberch cross in off the post, before illustrating his waning dominance in his own as Koki Ogawa beat him in the air from a corner in the 88th minute as Japan secured an unlikely point.

Takefusa Kubo had already equalised after Van Dijk's opener, firing a shot through Denzel Dumfries' legs, before Crycensio Summerville put the Netherlands back in front – just 11 days on from his international debut – with a lovely curled finish into the far corner following some excellent play in midfield by Gravenberch, as both he and Gakpo were much improved after the break.

Bart Verbruggen will take his fair share of the blame after getting both hands to Ogawa's late

header, even given the deflection off Daichi Kamada, and so will Koeman after setting his stall out to defend the Netherlands' 2-1 lead. "You're just inviting pressure," said Ange Postecoglou in the ITV studio after the Dutch boss brought a third centre-back on.

But Van Dijk should be steeling himself for criticism that's been handed out willingly by Dutch legends in the past.

"He was selected for the World Team of the Year. He thinks he's better than the rest," Ruud Gullit said in February 2023 "It is actually very strange that such a very good player does so little for the Dutch national team in the build-up," Marco Van Basten said in September 2022.

Just four months ago, [Gullit said](#): "I have been critical of Virgil van Dijk several times, because he's the Liverpool captain. Put it this way, if there is an orchestra where the violinist is not performing well, I'm not going to scream at the violinist, I'm going to be pointing the finger at the director.

Both have begrudgingly admitted Van Dijk's excellent defending in the past while hitting out at his leadership and work in possession, but this was a display – [after several for Liverpool this season](#) – which opens up that previously unimpeachable facet of the centre-back's game to censure.

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